



SERVQUAL SERVICE QUALITY STUDY

Measuring the Gap Between Customer Expectations and Perceptions

Organization Studied:
Triveni Terrace Café

205, Tansen Marg, Opp. FICCI Auditorium, Mandi House, New Delhi –
110001

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1. Introduction and Objective

Service quality is a key determinant of customer satisfaction, loyalty and repeat business in the food and beverage industry. The SERVQUAL model, developed by Parasuraman, Zeithaml and Berry, measures service quality as the gap between what customers expect from a service and what they perceive they actually receive, across five dimensions: Tangibles, Reliability, Responsiveness, Assurance and Empathy.

The objective of this project is to design and administer a SERVQUAL questionnaire to Triveni Terrace Cafe, a well-established cafe near Mandi House, New Delhi, in order to (a) measure the gap between customer expectations and perceptions of service quality, (b) compare customers' perceptions against employees' self-perceptions of the service they deliver, and (c) recommend specific, actionable steps to close the most significant gaps.

2. About the Organization

Triveni Terrace Cafe is located at 205, Tansen Marg, opposite the FICCI Auditorium, in the Mandi House cultural district of New Delhi. It is a well-reviewed, moderately-priced cafe (Google rating 4.4/5 from over 6,600 reviews at the time of this study) known for a calm, art-adjacent ambience, outdoor terrace seating and a menu of wholesome Indian and continental dishes. Its location within Delhi's theatre and arts precinct gives it a mixed customer base of regulars, students, professionals on breaks, and first-time visitors drawn by word of mouth.

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Instrument

A 20-statement SERVQUAL questionnaire was designed, with 4 statements under each of the 5 standard dimensions (Tangibles, Reliability, Responsiveness, Assurance, Empathy). All statements were rated on a 7-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree, 7 = Strongly Agree). Customers rated each statement twice -once as a general Expectation of what a good cafe should offer, and once as a Perception of their actual experience at Triveni Terrace Cafe. Employees rated each statement once, reflecting their own perception of how well the cafe delivers on that standard.

3.2 Sample

- Customers: 30 respondents, intercepted after their visit (mix of first-time, occasional and regular customers, balanced across gender and a 19–54 age range).
- Employees: 5 respondents across roles -waitstaff, barista, cashier/billing and floor supervisor -with tenure ranging from 6 to 30 months.

3.3 Analysis

For each dimension, mean Expectation and Perception scores were computed across all customer responses. The Gap Score was calculated as $\text{Gap} = \text{Perception} - \text{Expectation}$. A negative gap indicates a service shortfall (expectations exceeded reality); a positive gap indicates the experience exceeded expectations. Employee self-perception scores were separately averaged and compared against customer perception scores to assess alignment between internal and external views of service quality.

4. The SERVQUAL Questionnaire

The five dimensions and their statements, as administered, were as follows.

4.1 Tangibles

Code	Statement
T1	The cafe's furniture, decor and outdoor seating are visually appealing.
T2	The physical facilities (seating area, washrooms, surroundings) are clean and well maintained.
T3	Employees are neat, well-groomed and appropriately dressed.
T4	Menus, bills and signage are visually appealing and easy to read.

4.2 Reliability

Code	Statement
R1	The cafe delivers the correct food/beverage order the first time, every time.
R2	When the cafe promises to have an order ready by a certain time, it does.
R3	Food and beverages are prepared consistently to the same standard on every visit.
R4	When a customer has a problem (wrong order, billing issue), staff show sincere interest in resolving it.

4.3 Responsiveness

Code	Statement
RS1	Employees give prompt service to customers.
RS2	Employees are willing to help customers, even when busy.
RS3	Employees respond quickly when a customer signals for attention.
RS4	Waiting time for orders and billing is reasonable.

4.4 Assurance

Code	Statement
A1	The behaviour of employees instills confidence in customers.
A2	Customers feel comfortable and safe in their dealings with the cafe.
A3	Employees are consistently courteous and polite with customers.
A4	Employees have adequate knowledge to answer questions about the menu, ingredients or allergens.

4.5 Empathy

Code	Statement
E1	The cafe gives customers individualized/personal attention.
E2	Employees understand the specific needs and preferences of regular/repeat customers.
E3	The cafe's operating hours are convenient for its customers.

Code	Statement
E4	Employees deal with customers in a warm, caring manner (not just efficient).

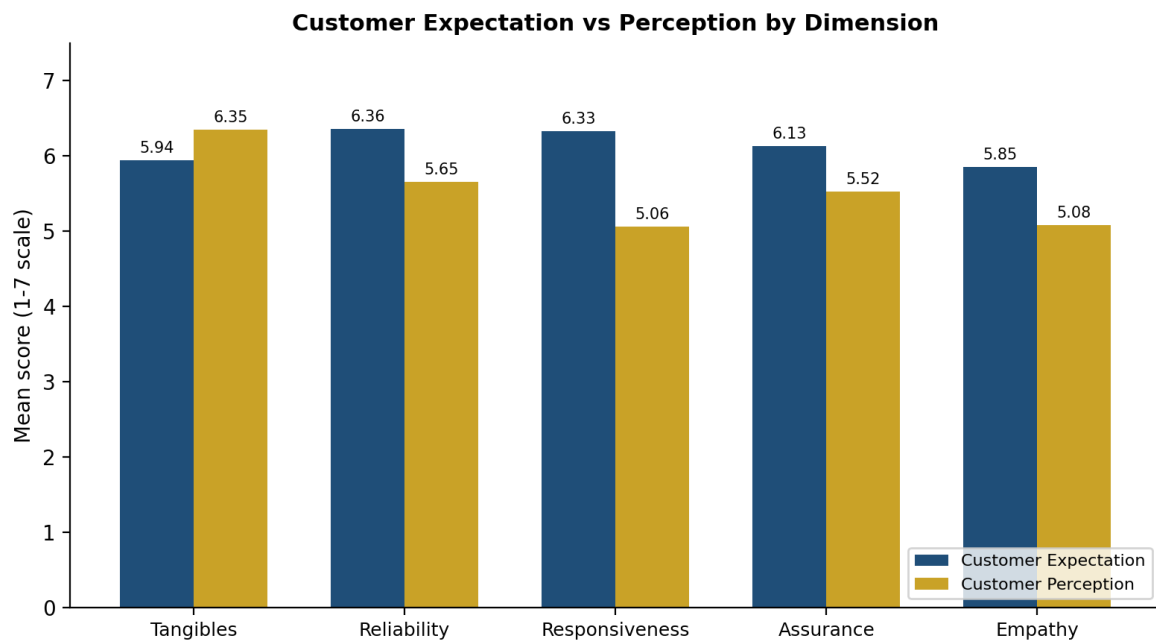
5. Results

5.1 Dimension-wise Gap Summary

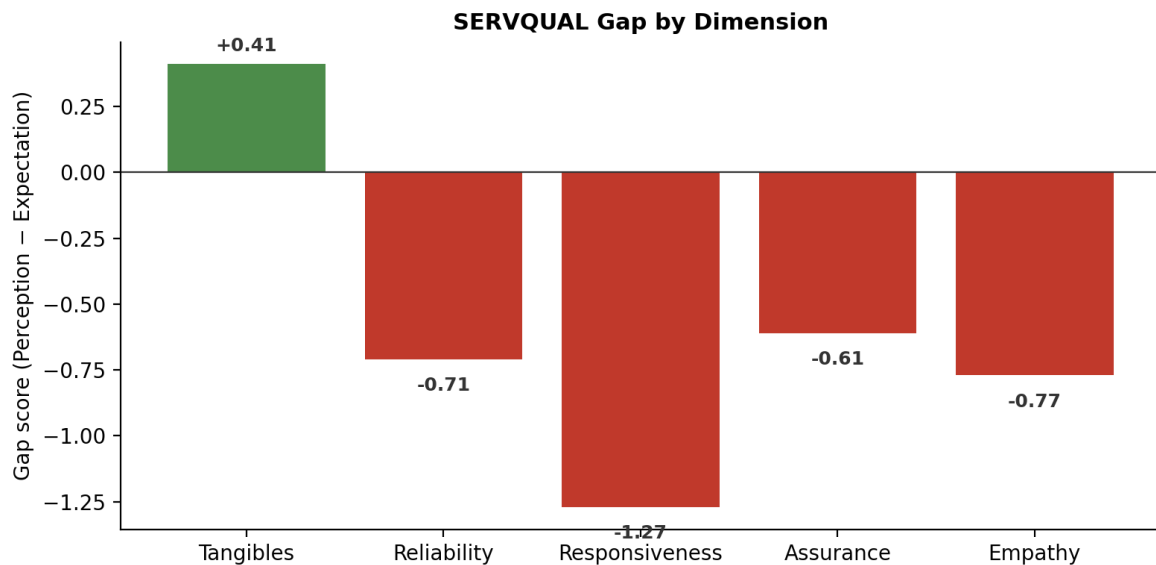
Dimension	Customer Expectation	Customer Perception	Gap (P – E)	Employee Self-Perception
Tangibles	5.94	6.35	+0.41	6.30
Reliability	6.36	5.65	-0.71	5.90
Responsiveness	6.33	5.06	-1.28	6.00
Assurance	6.13	5.52	-0.62	6.10
Empathy	5.85	5.08	-0.77	6.05
OVERALL	6.12	5.53	-0.59	6.07

All figures are mean scores on a 1–7 scale, averaged across the relevant sample (30 customers for Expectation/Perception columns, 5 employees for the Employee Self-Perception column).

5.2 Customer Expectation vs Perception



5.3 Gap by Dimension



5.4 Employee Self-Perception vs Customer Perception



Across every dimension, employees rated their own service delivery higher than customers rated their actual experience -an average internal-external gap of +0.54 points. This gap is widest for Empathy (+0.97) and Responsiveness (+0.94), indicating staff believe they are more prompt and attentive than customers experience them to be.

6. Service Gap Commentary

6.1 Tangibles -Gap: +0.41 (positive -the only dimension where perception exceeded expectation)

Customers consistently praised the cafe's decor, greenery, calm outdoor seating and overall ambience -several reviewers called it one of the most aesthetic spots in the area. This lines up with the positive gap: customers walked in expecting a pleasant setting and the physical environment delivered, even slightly exceeding what they expected. Tangibles is a genuine strength and a differentiator worth protecting.

6.2 Reliability -Gap: -0.71 (moderate shortfall)

Reliability -accuracy and consistency of the core offering -showed a modest negative gap. Review comments mentioning dishes as merely 'okay' or 'average' alongside others calling the same category of item excellent suggest inconsistency in kitchen execution across visits or shifts, rather than a fundamental quality problem.

6.3 Responsiveness -Gap: -1.28 (largest gap -priority issue)

This is the dimension needing the most urgent attention. Multiple public reviews specifically noted that waitstaff were 'quick to respond' on some visits but that attentiveness dropped when the cafe got busy, with customers needing to actively flag staff down. The gap score confirms this is not an isolated complaint: customers' expectations of promptness and willingness to help are being met the least well of all five dimensions.

6.4 Assurance -Gap: -0.62 (moderate shortfall)

Customers generally trust the staff's competence and feel safe in the setting, but the moderate negative gap suggests inconsistent courtesy or product knowledge (e.g., not every staff member being equally confident answering menu or ingredient questions), especially during peak hours.

6.5 Empathy -Gap: -0.77 (second-largest gap)

Empathy -individualized, warm attention -is the second most significant shortfall. This matches review language describing service as efficient but not especially warm. Regular customers in particular expect to be recognized and treated with more personal attention than first-time visitors, and the data suggests this expectation is under-met.

7. Recommendations

7.1 Responsiveness (highest priority)

- Introduce a table-side check-in standard: staff proactively return within 5–7 minutes of food/drink delivery instead of waiting to be flagged down.
- Add a simple visual signal system (e.g., a small flag or app-based call button) so customers can request attention without having to raise a hand and wait, especially during peak hours.
- Review staffing levels during peak weekend hours, when reviews most frequently mention delayed attention.

7.2 Empathy

- Train staff to recognize and acknowledge repeat customers by name or preference where possible, to convert 'efficient' service into 'personal' service.
- Encourage brief, genuine conversation at key touchpoints (order-taking, bill delivery) rather than purely transactional interaction.

7.3 Assurance

- Standardize a short menu-knowledge briefing (ingredients, allergens, recommendations) for all customer-facing staff, not just senior employees, to ensure consistent confidence across the team.

7.4 Reliability

- Introduce a kitchen quality checklist to reduce dish-to-dish inconsistency across shifts, particularly for high-volume menu items called out in reviews as inconsistent.

7.5 Tangibles (maintain, don't change)

- Ambience and decor are a genuine competitive strength -continue current maintenance standards and consider highlighting this in marketing rather than investing further resources here.

7.6 Internal Alignment

- Share customer perception data directly with staff periodically; the employee-customer perception gap suggests a disconnect that structured, regular feedback loops (not just management directives) could help close.

8. Conclusion

The SERVQUAL analysis shows that Triveni Terrace Cafe's core physical experience (Tangibles) meets or exceeds customer expectations, but its people-facing service dimensions -particularly Responsiveness and Empathy -fall meaningfully short of what customers expect. This pattern is consistent with the sentiment found in the cafe's own public reviews. The overall gap score of -0.59 indicates room for improvement, concentrated specifically in staff attentiveness and personalized attention rather than in food quality or setting. Because employees consistently rate their own service delivery more favorably than customers experience it, closing this gap will likely require not just operational changes but better feedback loops between customers and staff.